

Running Little Syria backward

Assignment 03 · a hindcast of my Assignment 2 map (people reporting Arab ancestry, ACS Table B04006), from about 2020 to 1900 · [your name]

1 • What I am attempting

My Assignment 2 map shows where New Yorkers report Arab ancestry today, with landmarks as a second layer. It is about arrival and disappearance, yet it can only show the end of the story: one landmarked church stands for a colony of roughly 1,200–1,500 people on Washington Street around 1900 (press estimates; to check against Jacobs 2015). I want to run the ancestry layer **backward**, one decade at a time, to ask where today's households would have been earlier and how a dense Lower Manhattan colony thinned into a city-wide scatter. Before 1980 the census asked only where people and their parents were born, never ancestry, so a map of arrival cannot be read from data; it can only be estimated. My aim is not to "recover" 1900 but to draw the trail *together with* how uncertain it is.

2 • The dataset and my record

Who, when, why. U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey (ACS) 5-year estimates, Table B04006, "People Reporting Ancestry." The ancestry question began in the 1980 census and entered the ACS in 2005, when it replaced the long form; it informs federal programs and planning. I use the "Arab" total for every NYC tract (about 2,300 rows; I will confirm the count in my file). Only the first two ancestries a person gives are tabulated, and any generation can answer, so the table counts *identification*, not immigrants. **The dots** on my map are NYC Landmarks Preservation Commission designations from NYC Open Data: every landmark in the city, not only Arab ones. Little Syria has just one, St. George's Church at 103 Washington St. (designated 2009), which I highlighted in red by hand. The tenement and the Downtown Community House beside it are not designated, so the dots cannot show them: the layer records what the city chose to protect, not what was lost.

GEOID	borough	place (my label)	arab_est	arab_moe	x_ft, y_ft (EPSG:2263)	dist_ft_StGeorge	landmarks_n
text, 11 digits	county FIPS	text	people	people, 90% MOE	feet	feet	count
36061...	New York	Lower Manhattan (Washington St)	60	±25	...	≈ 0–1,500	1–3
36047...	Kings	Brooklyn Heights / Atlantic Ave	250	±60	...	≈ 12,000	many
36047...	Kings	Bay Ridge	900	±130	...	≈ 42,000	few
36085...	Richmond	Staten Island, south shore	700	±150	...	≈ 80,000	0–1

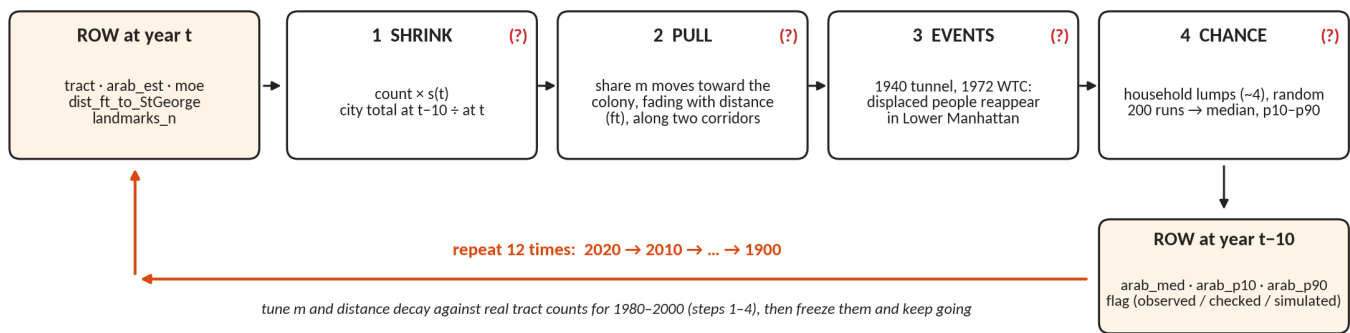
Record. These rows, one per tract, are my starting state. The date is the ACS window behind my Assignment 2 map, treated as "2020." *Values above are invented placeholders, to be replaced from my Assignment 2 file*; dist_ft_StGeorge and landmarks_n are new columns I would compute from the church point and the LPC dots (feet, because EPSG:2263 is in feet).

New hand-made layer: more Arab marks. A short list, one row each (address, year, source), which the run should pass near: St. George's Church, 103 Washington St (landmark 2009) · St. Joseph's Maronite, 127 Washington St (c. 1890) · 81 Washington St (1900–03) · 295 Hicks St, Brooklyn (1903–44) · Our Lady of Lebanon Cathedral, 113 Remsen St (1944–) · Atlantic Ave, Court to Hicks St (the "Syrian shopping center" of the 1950s–60s) · Elizabeth H. Berger Plaza, 2 Edgar St (Al *Qalam* monument, 30 April 2026). Sources: Brooklyn Public Library history blog, nycago.org parish history, news reports; addresses still to verify.

3 • Research

- **Backward projection.** Demographers reverse population models to estimate earlier counts (Preston, Heuveline & Guillot, *Demography: Measuring and Modeling Population Processes*, 2001). My "shrink" step is a crude version: scale by a city total, then redistribute.
- **Direction of movement.** Massey's spatial assimilation model (1985, *Sociology and Social Research* 69): groups start in central enclaves and disperse outward as they settle. Local history agrees on the first move, to Brooklyn (Jacobs 2015; Kayal & Benson 2002).
- **Households as rules plus chance.** Schelling, "Dynamic Models of Segregation" (1971, *J. Mathematical Sociology* 1(2)): simple moving rules, repeated, draw whole city patterns.
- **Changing tracts.** Logan, Xu & Stults (2014, *Professional Geographer* 66(3)): the Longitudinal Tract Database bridges boundaries back to 1970. I would use census tract tables for 1980–2000 to check the run.
- **Not found:** a published tract-level hindcast of Arab New York. Looked in: Census Bureau ancestry documentation, IPUMS bibliography and LTDB pages, the studio readings.

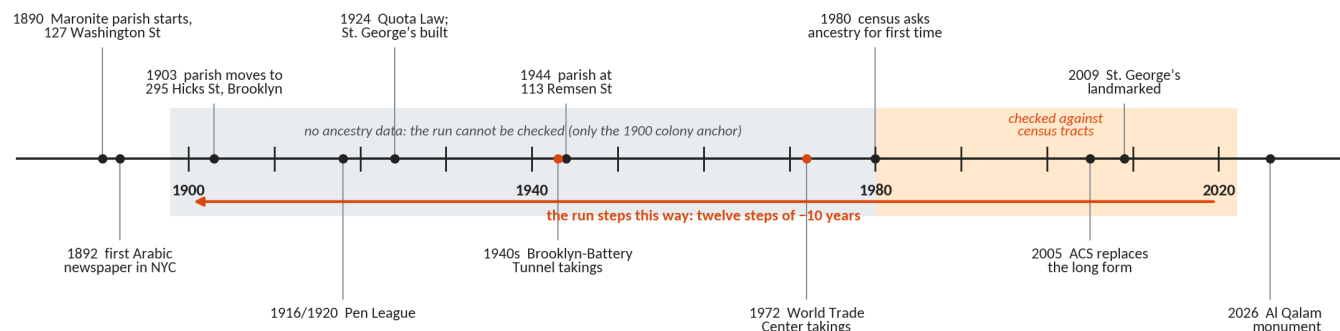
4 • My rule (what happens to each row at every step back of ten years)



1 Shrink	Count × s(t), where s(t) = city-wide Arab-origin total at t-10 ÷ total at t. From: census totals (ancestry 1980–2000; birthplace of person and parents before 1980). Which birthplaces count as "Arab" is my choice. (?)
2 Pull	A share m of each tract's people is reassigned to other tracts; weights fall off with distance (ft) from the Washington St. colony and run along two corridors (to Brooklyn Heights/Atlantic Ave until about 1960, then on to Bay Ridge). From: direction from Massey, Jacobs, the BPL blog; m, the distance decay and the corridor weights are mine, tuned on 1980–2000. (?)
3 Events	At the 1940 and 1970 steps, extra people are placed in Lower Manhattan tracts: those displaced by the Brooklyn-Battery Tunnel and World Trade Center takings. From: dates in the studio brief; how many people is unknown, mine. (?)
4 Chance	The start count is drawn from estimate ± margin of error; people move in household lumps of about 4. From: ACS margin of error; lump size is mine. (?) (?) = least sure

5 • My run

Step: –10 years, twelve times, from 2020 back to 1900. **Left to chance:** the starting counts, which households move, and the size of the two events; 200 runs, keeping the median and the 10th–90th percentile band. **Checking:** the first four steps (2020 → 1980) are compared with real tract counts from the 1980, 1990 and 2000 censuses; I tune m and the distance decay there, then freeze them. Beyond 1980 there is nothing to check against except one anchor: Lower Manhattan tracts should hold roughly 1,200–1,500 people in 1900.

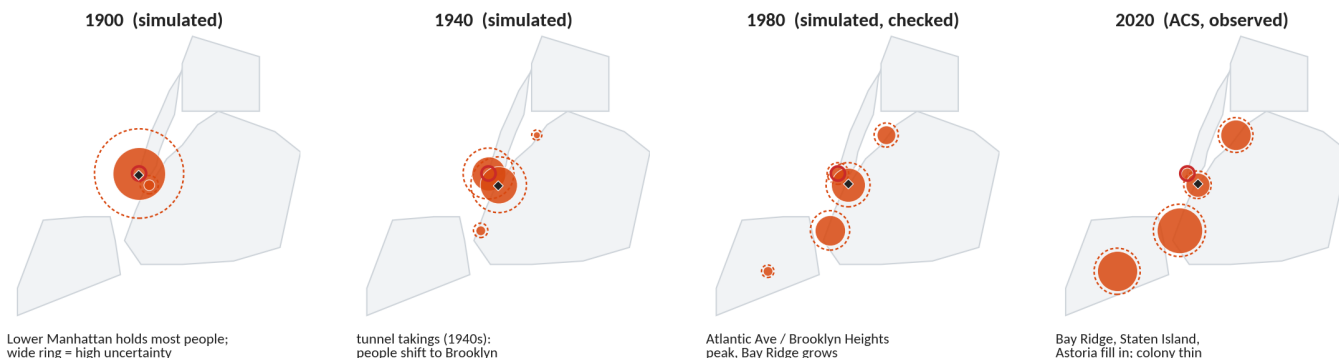


The timeline the run steps through. Dates: studio brief (1924, 1940s, 1972, 2009, 2026), Census Bureau (1980, 2005), nycago.org parish history (1890–1944).

6 • The data it would generate

tract	year	step	arab_med	arab_p10	arab_p90	flag
Lower Manhattan	2020	0	60	40	85	observed (ACS ± MOE)
Lower Manhattan	1980	4	120	80	170	checked against census
Lower Manhattan	1940	8	500	280	780	simulated
Lower Manhattan	1900	12	1,200	700	1,700	simulated; anchored to colony
Brooklyn Hts / Atlantic Ave	1940	8	600	380	840	simulated
Brooklyn Hts / Atlantic Ave	1980	4	500	380	630	checked against census
Bay Ridge	1980	4	400	320	490	checked against census
Staten Island, south shore	1980	4	40	20	70	checked against census

Tract-year table, invented numbers to show the shape. Every tract gets one row per decade (about $2,300 \times 13$), with the median and range of the 200 runs.



ILLUSTRATIVE SKETCH, invented numbers. Orange disc = people reporting Arab ancestry (area proportional to count); dashed ring = p10–p90 range from 200 runs; red ring = St. George's Church (landmarked 2009); black diamond = Maronite parish at its address that year (81 Washington St, 295 Hicks St, 113 Remsen St).

7 • What it cannot see

- Ancestry is not migration.** Counts include later generations, so going back people vanish because descendants vanish. Before 1980 the data are birthplaces, a different thing.
- Categories drift.** “Syrian” around 1900 meant Greater Syria (today's Lebanon, Syria, Palestine, Jordan); “Arab” was not a federal category until MENA in 2024. Religion, class and language are invisible.
- Small numbers are noisy.** Many tracts have large margins of error, so pockets such as south Staten Island may be partly noise, and the ACS ignores third ancestries.
- A closed city.** Moves to New Jersey, Detroit or back overseas are not counted. Boundaries of tracts also change over time.
- Landmarks are not memory.** The dots record city decisions; lost buildings, newspapers, the Pen League and the people displaced by the takings do not appear, and the rule turns eviction into a number.